

The Amazon

The world's largest river, snaking through the most extensive rain forest on Earth and supporting a unique ecosystem



The greatest river on Earth, measured by both the size of its catchment area and the volume of water flowing through its channels, the Amazon carries one-fifth of all the freshwater entering Earth's oceans. Its vast basin drains more than 40 percent of South America. About two-thirds of its main stream and by far the largest portion of its catchment is in Brazil. The Amazon and more than 1,000 tributaries support the great biodiversity of the world's largest rain forest, with which it shares its name (see pp.120–21). Although the source of the Amazon (see p.108) and its total length have been the subject of much debate, it is widely regarded the world's second longest river, after the Nile (see pp.190–91).



The Amazon rises high in the Andes of southern Peru, less than 125 miles (200km) from the Pacific Coast, and flows more than 4,000 miles (6,400km) to the northeast coast of Brazil, where it discharges an average of 53 billion gallons (200 billion liters) every second into the Atlantic Ocean. During flooding, some parts of the Amazon can reach a width of more than 30 miles (50km). The river's estuary spans an area more than 185 miles (300km) wide.

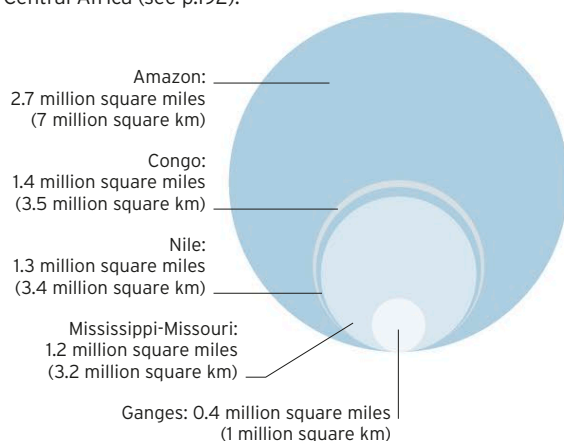
◁ FIERCE REPUTATION

Despite its reputation as a ferocious predator, the red-bellied piranha mainly forages and scavenges for food and travels in schools for protection against larger predators.

The Amazon carries **more water** than the **next seven largest rivers** combined

EARTH'S LARGEST RIVER BASINS

A river's drainage basin, also known as its catchment area, is the total area of land that is drained of water by the river and all its tributaries. The Amazon has by far the largest drainage basin of any river on Earth. Its area is about twice the size of the next largest, that of the Congo in Central Africa (see p.192).



△ VIGOROUS GROWER

The water hyacinth is fast-growing, and outside its native range of the Amazon Basin it can be highly invasive, blocking up waterways and inhibiting other wildlife.

▷ WIDE LOOPS

A large part of the Amazon Basin is flat, and for much of its course the river and many of its tributaries meander slowly through vast areas of pristine rain forest.

